PRELUDE XXI

THIS fantasia is not a duet between the right hand and the left. A vivid idea of the musical meaning of its opening may be obtained by asking a good violinist to play the following passage in several different ways of bowing and of nuance:



By this it is not implied that the pianist should imitate the violin in any particular bowing or tone; nor does the transposition and the harmonisation of the fourth and eighth quaver here given mean anything but the practical needs of the violin. But the experiment will at once reveal what every clavichord player felt in his finger-tips and every pianist has to discover by research—viz., that the only possible musical or instrumental point of these passages implies the closest connection of the two hands as a single implement. Similarly, the object of dividing scale-passages between the hands, as in bars 3 and 4, was not anything antiphonal, but, on the contrary, to secure rapidity and to avoid the " passage of the thumb." (The exact technique has been modernised by Debussy in his *Étude pour les huit Doigts*.)

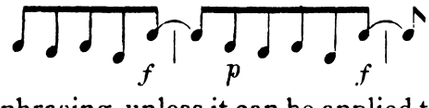
The bracketed directions, *Adagio* and *Presto*, in bars 11 and 13, rest on old and intelligent tradition, and should be acted on to an extent which does not destroy the shape of the bar. The big chords should be slightly broken, and the tied demisemiquavers allowed to sing before the runs break away. With bar 15 the tone softens and deepens: with the minor scale, in bar 16, the demisemiquavers broaden into declamatory style, which becomes deliberate recitative in the second crotchet of bar 17. From this point the other chords, besides that marked by Bach, should be slowly rolled, and the moving inner parts made to sing.

In bar 18 the *tempo* (at the second crotchet) revives a little. The mordent in bar 19 should be rather slow, and the end should float away calmly, neither to be hastened nor impeded. The listener should feel that the last note (though sustained till it dies away) is mysteriously poised on the end of the bar instead of an accented beat.

The old reading that adds a low B♭ octave in an additional bar is perhaps the most Philistine single printed chord in the whole history of music.

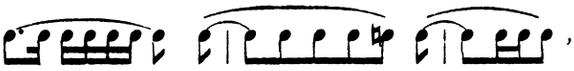
FUGUE XXI

FROM bar 30-33 the behaviour of the middle voice misleads the eye and the hand to phrase the treble (as Czerny, following Beethoven, indicates) with decided *sforzandos*, thus:



There is little point in such phrasing, unless it can be applied to the theme to which it belongs—to say nothing of bars 33-34, where most players have already forgotten it, or bars 19-21, where

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it occurs to nobody. The theme to which the sequence belongs is the Subject, of which it is the inverted first figure. If any special emphasis is worth while in bars 30-33, the ground for it may be prepared by Bischoff's phrasing, which marks the corresponding notes of the Subject to be detached (as to the joint between bars 1-2 and 2-3). But there is, on the whole, much to be said for phrasing the Subject simply according to its figures—*i.e.*, making a *legato* over the six quavers from the F to the C inclusive; starting again with the semiquavers in bar 2, and proceeding in one bow to the D in bar 3; then starting again with the long semiquaver run and drifting without break into the First Countersubject (bar 5). Note that the first six semiquavers of bar 3 are the inversion of those in bar 2. Thus, within the Subject itself and the above-discussed Episodes, we have the main figures constantly being inverted, though the Subject as a whole is (for this very reason) never given by inversion. As to the First Countersubject, Bischoff is indisputably right in making the tied notes the beginnings instead of the ends of *legato* phrases, if there are to be any breaks at all. His phrasing, then, is  , etc. and no other division will do justice to the suspended discords. The only open question is whether this Countersubject may not as well be entirely unbroken until those merry repeated notes assert the one self-evident *staccato* in the composition. It is quite certain that no other actual *staccatos* are harmonically tolerable. The harmonies of this Fugue have suffered tortures from the "*legato*-semiquaver against *staccato*-quaver" rule of thumb for Bach-grinders.

The Second Countersubject (which should be quite as distinct as the rest) throws in its fluttering semiquaver exclamations, completing a most efficient though absurdly light triple counterpoint at every entry of the Subject. The two Episodes are formed by letting the semiquavers of the Subject roll on in long sequence, while the inverted first figure of the Subject insinuates itself in combination. The *tempo* is lively enough for the last four bars to give considerable trouble, however they are fingered.